BONUS 5 OF 6

Sell Your First Batch This Weekend

Pricing, packaging & your state's cottage food rules

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> *You do not need a storefront, a big budget or a business degree to sell your first bag of gourmet popcorn. You need a recipe you trust, a fair price, a clean label and ten people who know you exist. This guide walks you through all four, in plain English, so you can have your first sales this weekend.*

> **Read this first**
>
> This guide is educational. It is not legal, tax or financial advice. Rules about selling homemade food differ by state and sometimes by county or city, and they change. Always confirm the current rules with your official state or local source before you sell. Earnings are never guaranteed: some people sell out in an afternoon, others take weeks to find their first customers.

1. Set honest expectations

Selling popcorn is a small, friendly side project, not a get-rich-quick plan. Most home sellers start with family, neighbors and a few local events. A realistic first goal is not a number of dollars. It is ten happy customers who pay you and tell a friend.

Popcorn has real advantages. The ingredients are cheap, a batch takes 20 to 30 minutes, the finished product is dry and light, and a bag looks generous on a table. It also has limits: you will spend time on shopping, packing and labeling, and your first batches will teach you things no guide can.

- Plan to **break even or earn a small amount** on the first weekend. That is a win.
- Your time counts. Track it, even if you decide not to charge for all of it at first.
- Start small: two or three flavors, three bag sizes, one weekend.
- Keep a notebook of what people say. Their comments are your best free market research.

2. Know your cost per bag

Price starts with cost. Add up everything that goes into one bag, then decide what you want to earn on top. Do this once with real receipts, not guesses.

The four costs

- **Ingredients:** popcorn kernels, butter or oil, sugar, candy melts, chocolate, seasonings, toppings. Divide the cost of each package by how many batches it makes.
- **Packaging:** the bag or tin, a tie or sticker to close it, and a ribbon or card if you use one.
- **Label:** printed label, paper and ink, or a label printed at a copy shop.
- **Your time:** shopping, making, cooling, packing and delivering. Even a modest hourly figure makes the picture honest.

Sample cost sheet: one batch of caramel-style popcorn (about 12 cups)

These numbers are examples only. Grocery prices vary by store and by month. Use your own receipts.

ITEM	EXAMPLE COST	NOTES
Popcorn kernels (about 1/2 cup yields 12 cups popped)	$0.40	From a larger jar or bag
Butter, sugar, syrup, vanilla	$1.60	Cost of the amounts used
Topping (sprinkles, nuts or chocolate drizzle)	$0.75	Check allergens
Total ingredients, one batch	$2.75	Makes about 12 cups
Packaging for 6 small bags	$1.50	Bags and ties
Labels for 6 bags	$0.60	Paper and ink
Time: 1 hour at $10/hour (shopping, making, packing)	$10.00	Adjust to your own number
Total for the batch	$14.85	About $2.48 per small bag

In this example, one batch makes six small bags of about 2 cups each, so each bag costs roughly $2.48 once your time is included. Without counting your time it is about $0.81 per bag. Knowing both numbers keeps you honest.

3. Price your bags

A common starting rule is to charge at least two to three times your ingredient and packaging cost, then check that your time is covered. Gourmet snacks are a treat, so people expect to pay more than for a supermarket bag, but not so much that they hesitate.

Three bag sizes to offer

SIZE	APPROX. CONTENTS	EXAMPLE COST INCL. PACKAGING	EXAMPLE PRICE TO TEST
Snack bag	2 cups	$1.00	$4
Gift bag	6 cups	$2.80	$10
Party tin or large bag	12 cups	$5.50	$18

Prices here are only a starting point to test. Look at what local bakeries, craft sellers and market vendors charge near you, then set your price in the same range. If everything sells in the first hour, you

may be too low. If nothing sells after several events, check your price, your photos and your message before blaming the popcorn.

> **Tip**
> Offer a simple bundle: three snack bags for a little less than three single ones. Bundles raise the average sale and make gift buying easy.

4. What sells

Start with flavors people already recognize, then add one surprise. Familiar gets the first sale, surprising gets the repeat order.

- **Everyday favorites:** classic caramel, chocolate drizzle, white cheddar-style cheese, kettle-style sweet and salty.
- **Crowd pleasers for kids:** rainbow sprinkle, birthday cake, unicorn, cookies-and-cream style.
- **Savory options:** cheese, ranch-style, garlic and herb, mild spicy.
- **One signature flavor:** the recipe people ask about. Name it something memorable.

Seasons and occasions

Demand follows the calendar. Plan one or two themed flavors per season and announce them two to three weeks ahead.

SEASON	IDEAS
Fall	Halloween colors, caramel apple style, Thanksgiving gift bags, teacher gifts
Winter	Christmas red and green, peppermint-style, holiday party tins
Spring	Valentine's pink and red, Easter pastels, baby showers, graduations
Summer	Fourth of July red-white-blue, summer cookouts, ball games, birthday parties
All year	Movie night, game day, bake sales, teacher gifts, birthday party favors

Keep the number of flavors small at first. Three to four flavors in three sizes is plenty. Fewer choices mean less waste and faster decisions at a table.

5. Packaging and labels

Good packaging does two jobs: it keeps popcorn fresh and crisp, and it makes your product look worth the price. Use clean, food-safe bags or tins with a good seal. Clear bags show off the colors; add a sticker or a card so it looks finished.

- Fill bags loosely. Crushed popcorn looks sad and sells poorly.

- Let every batch cool and dry completely before bagging, or the bag will fog and the popcorn may go soft.
- Keep a spare bag of each flavor for photos and for samples.
- Store finished bags in a cool, dry place, out of sunlight.

What a label usually includes

Requirements differ by state, so treat this as a starting list and check your state's labeling rules before you print anything.

COMMON LABEL ITEMS TO CONFIRM FOR YOUR STATE

- [ ] Name of the product (for example, Caramel Crunch Popcorn)
- [ ] Ingredients list, in order from the largest amount to the smallest
- [ ] Allergens clearly named (for example milk, soy, tree nuts, peanuts, wheat)
- [ ] Net weight or volume, as your state requires
- [ ] Your name or business name as the producer
- [ ] Your city and state (some states want a full address)
- [ ] Any required statement such as 'Made in a home kitchen', if your state requires it
- [ ] Date made or a best-by date, if your state requires or suggests it

> **Check your state's labeling rules**
> Some states require exact wording on the label. Others have rules about print size or where the statement goes. Look up the labeling section of your state's cottage food guidance before ordering stickers in bulk.

6. Cottage food laws in the USA: a plain-English summary

> **Important: laws change**
> This section is a general orientation, not legal advice. Cottage food rules are set by each state and can change every year. Counties and cities may add rules. Always check the official source for your state before you sell.

What is a cottage food law?

A cottage food law lets people make certain low-risk foods in a home kitchen and sell them directly to customers, without renting a commercial kitchen. The goal is to help small producers while keeping food safe. Each state writes its own version.

Why popcorn usually fits

Cottage food laws usually focus on foods that do not need refrigeration and are considered low risk for spoilage: baked goods, candies, dry mixes and similar products. Popcorn is a dry, shelf-stable snack, so in most states it can be sold under cottage food rules. Some states list popcorn directly; others cover it under a broader category such as candy or snack foods. Items with fresh dairy or other perishable toppings may be treated differently. Check the rules for your exact recipe.

How to find your state's rules in *5* minutes

1. Search for **cottage food law [your state]**.
2. Open the result from an official site, usually ending in .gov. Skip blogs for the final answer.
3. Find the agency in charge. It is often the state Department of Agriculture or Department of Health, or your county health department.
4. Look for the list of allowed foods. Confirm popcorn, candy-coated popcorn and your toppings are included.
5. Write down: registration or license needed, annual sales limit, whether you can sell online or ship, label requirements, and any required food safety course.

Questions to ask for every state

- Do I need to register or get a permit, and what does it cost?
- Is there a limit on yearly sales?
- Can I sell online, at markets, to stores, or only directly to people?
- Can I ship across state lines? (Often more restricted than local sales.)
- What must be on my label?
- Do I need a food handler or food safety course?
- Do I need a home inspection or a water test?

State-by-state starting point

The table below summarizes what we found for popcorn and similar low-risk foods in each state: which agency regulates it, whether popcorn is covered, whether you need a license or registration, any annual sales limit we could confirm, and what the state says about online or mail sales. Where we could not confirm a detail in an official source, it says “Unclear” or “Check source”: look it up before you sell.

Compiled from official state sources (October 2026)

We researched each state's official cottage food information for non-refrigerated, low-risk foods like popcorn. “Unclear” or “Check source” means we could not confirm it in an official source. Rules and limits change often, and counties and cities can add their own. Always confirm with your state agency before you sell.

STATE	REGULATING AGENCY	POPCORN ALLOWED?	LICENSE / REGISTRATION	ANNUAL SALES LIMIT	ONLINE / MAIL SALES	KEY NOTE
Alabama	Alabama Department of Public Health	Limited	Required	No cap found	Restricted	Candy listed, popcorn not named; county review form, food safety course; in-state only.
Alaska	Alaska Department of Environmental Conservation	Yes	Not required	Check source	Restricted	No state permit; label sign required; no interstate sales; local rules apply.
Arizona	Arizona Department of Health Services	Yes	Required	No cap found	Restricted	Free online registration; food handler course; production date and registration number on label.
Arkansas	Arkansas Department of Health	Yes	Not required	No cap found	Allowed	Food Freedom Act: non-TCS foods to informed end consumer; internet sales exempt.
California	California Department of Public Health	Yes	Varies by county	$86,206 (Class A) / $172,411 (Class B), 2025 adjusted	Restricted	Local registration (Class A) or permit (Class B); candied popcorn on approved list.
Colorado	Colorado Department of Public Health and Environment	Limited	Not required	$10,000 per product	Restricted	Popcorn not named; Colorado-only sales; no wholesale; 2026 bill may change rules.
Connecticut	Department of Consumer Protection	Yes	Required	$50,000	Not allowed	$50 license; food safety course; in-person sales only, no mail or delivery services.
Delaware	Division of Public Health, Department of Health and Social Services	Unclear	Required	Check source	Not allowed	Annual $30 registration permit; approved product list; online sales prohibited, marketing allowed.
Florida	Department of Agriculture and Consumer Services	Yes	Not required	$250,000	Allowed	Popcorn approved; internet and mail order allowed; no wholesale; prepackaged samples only.
Georgia	Georgia Department of Agriculture	Yes	Not required	No cap found	Restricted	HB 398 (July 2025) removed license; online and retail sales allowed; no interstate.
Hawaii	Hawaii Department of Health, Food Safety Branch	Limited	Unclear	Check source	Unclear	Popcorn was on old DOH list; 2024 HB 2144 rules being updated.
Idaho	Idaho Department of Health and Welfare / local public health districts	Yes	Varies by county	Check source	Unclear	Popcorn listed as non-TCS cottage food; SB 1283 changed rule 2026.
Illinois	Local county health departments (Illinois Department of Public Health)	Yes	Required	No cap found	Unclear	Annual county registration, $50 fee cap, food manager certificate required.

STATE	REGULATING AGENCY	POPCORN ALLOWED?	LICENSE / REGISTRATION	ANNUAL SALES LIMIT	ONLINE / MAIL SALES	KEY NOTE
Indiana	Indiana Department of Health (local health departments)	Yes	Not required	No cap found	Restricted	Non-hazardous foods only; food safety training and label statement required.
Iowa	Iowa Department of Inspections, Appeals, and Licensing	Yes	Not required	No cap found	Unclear	Non-TCS foods sold direct to consumers exempt; labeling required.
Kansas	Kansas Department of Agriculture	Yes	Not required	No cap found	Allowed	No formal cottage law; non-TCS foods exempt; direct-to-consumer only.
Kentucky	Kentucky Department for Public Health, Food Safety Branch	Yes	Required	$60,000	Restricted	Home-based processor registration; popcorn listed shelf-stable; internet sales need commercial permit.
Louisiana	Louisiana Department of Health	Unclear	Not required	$30,000	Unclear	Low-risk foods exempt under R.S. 40:4.9; popcorn not confirmed; warning label.
Maine	Maine Department of Agriculture, Conservation and Forestry	Limited	Required	No cap found	Unclear	Home Food Processing License for shelf-stable foods; some towns exempt locally.
Maryland	Maryland Department of Health, Office of Food Protection	Yes	Not required	$50,000	Restricted	Maryland-only sales; popcorn not named officially; non-hazardous foods qualify.
Massachusetts	Massachusetts Department of Public Health (Food Protection Program) and local boards of health	Limited	Required	No cap found	Unclear	Residential kitchen permit via local board of health; popcorn listing unconfirmed officially.
Michigan	Michigan Department of Agriculture and Rural Development (MDARD)	Yes	Not required	$50,000	Restricted	Popcorn approved; registration optional; in-state internet sales need direct producer interaction.
Minnesota	Minnesota Department of Agriculture	Unclear	Required	$78,000	Restricted	Annual registration; internet sales allowed but human food cannot be shipped.
Mississippi	Mississippi State Department of Health	Yes	Not required	$35,000	Not allowed	Non-hazardous foods only; no internet or mail-order sales; face-to-face only.
Missouri	Missouri Department of Health and Senior Services	Unclear	Not required	Check source	Unclear	Statute lists baked goods, jams, dried herbs; popcorn not confirmed.
Montana	Montana Department of Public Health and Human Services	Limited	Required	No cap found	Restricted	Local registration (exempt at farmers markets); order online, hand off in person.
Nebraska	Nebraska Department of Agriculture	Yes	Required	No cap found	Restricted	Free one-time registration; food safety course; Nebraska-only direct-to-consumer sales.
Nevada	Nevada Division of Public and Behavioral Health and local health districts	Yes	Required	$35,000	Not allowed	Popcorn listed; register with local health authority; no internet sales.
New Hampshire	New Hampshire Department of Health and Human Services (Food Protection Section)	Limited	Not required	No cap found	Restricted	License-exempt for home or market sales; online or mail needs Homestead license.

STATE	REGULATING AGENCY	POPCORN ALLOWED?	LICENSE / REGISTRATION	ANNUAL SALES LIMIT	ONLINE / MAIL SALES	KEY NOTE
New Jersey	New Jersey Department of Health	Limited	Required	$50,000	Restricted	Permit and manager certificate; online orders allowed, no shipping, delivery within NJ only.
New Mexico	New Mexico Environment Department (Food Program)	Yes	Not required	No cap found	Unclear	Direct-to-consumer only; no NMED permit; check local city/county rules.
New York	NY Dept. of Agriculture and Markets	Limited	Required	No cap found	Restricted	Plain popcorn/caramel corn only; no chocolate topping; online in-state only.
North Carolina	NC Dept. of Agriculture and Consumer Services (Food and Drug Protection)	Unclear	Required	No cap found	Unclear	Home Processor program with kitchen inspection; confirm popcorn eligibility.
North Dakota	North Dakota Health and Human Services (Food and Lodging)	Unclear	Unclear	No cap found	Unclear	Cottage Food Act: direct sales to informed consumers; popcorn not confirmed.
Ohio	Ohio Department of Agriculture	Yes	Not required	Check source	Unclear	Popcorn and caramel corn listed in OAC 901:3-20; no vacuum packaging.
Oklahoma	Oklahoma Dept. of Agriculture, Food and Forestry	Yes	Not required	Check source	Unclear	Homemade Food Freedom Act; not-inspected disclosure required; confirm cap and shipping.
Oregon	Oregon Department of Agriculture	Yes	Not required	$50,000 (inflation-indexed)	Allowed	SB 643 added popcorn; food handler course, records, homemade label required.
Pennsylvania	Pennsylvania Department of Agriculture	Limited	Required	No cap found	Allowed	Limited Food Establishment registration, $35; popcorn not named, confirm with PDA.
Rhode Island	Rhode Island Department of Health (Center for Food Protection)	Unclear	Required	Check source	Unclear	Registration needed; unclear whether caramel corn qualifies as nonperishable baked good.
South Carolina	SC Department of Agriculture	Yes	Not required	No cap found	Allowed	Online and mail orders allowed; no registration; optional ID number for labels.
South Dakota	SD Department of Health (Office of Food and Lodging Safety)	Limited	Unclear	Check source	Restricted	Direct-to-consumer only; popcorn not named; confirm permit and training with Health Department.
Tennessee	Tennessee Department of Agriculture	Yes	Not required	No cap found	Unclear	Food Freedom Act exempts home foods from licensing; prohibited-list approach, popcorn not named.
Texas	Texas Department of State Health Services	Yes	Not required	$50,000	Unclear	Popcorn listed as allowed; $50,000 gross cap; confirm current online-sales rule.
Utah	Utah Department of Agriculture and Food	Yes	Required	No cap found	Restricted	Popcorn and popcorn balls permitted; registration, inspection, food handler permit; in-state sales only.
Vermont	Vermont Department of Health	Yes	Required	$30,000	Unclear	Annual exemption filing and training; no sales to restaurants; home-kitchen label required.

STATE	REGULATING AGENCY	POPCORN ALLOWED?	LICENSE / REGISTRATION	ANNUAL SALES LIMIT	ONLINE / MAIL SALES	KEY NOTE
Virginia	Virginia Department of Agriculture and Consumer Services (VDACS)	Yes	Not required	No cap found	Not allowed	Popcorn is low-risk exempt food; no online ordering, payment or shipping options.
Washington	Washington State Department of Agriculture	Unclear	Required	Check source	Restricted	Cottage food permit required before selling; popcorn not confirmed; no shipping; in-person sales.
West Virginia	West Virginia Department of Agriculture	Yes	Not required	No cap found	Restricted	Shelf-stable cottage foods sold only inside West Virginia; check current SB 44 rules.
Wisconsin	Wisconsin Department of Agriculture, Trade and Consumer Protection (DATCP)	Limited	Unclear	Check source	Unclear	No statutory cottage law; popcorn exemption and court rulings apply; confirm with DATCP.
Wyoming	Wyoming Department of Agriculture	Yes	Not required	No cap found	Unclear	Food Freedom Act exempts non-hazardous homemade foods; seller must disclose product is uninspected.

> **Verify before you sell**
>
> Agency names and rules change. Treat this table as a map of what to ask, not as the answer. Confirm everything with your official state or county source, and ask them directly if something is unclear. If you plan to ship across state lines, check both your state and the destination state.

7. Your first 10 customers

Ten customers is a very reachable goal. You do not need ads or a website. You need to tell people, show a photo and make it easy to say yes.

Where to find them

- **Family and friends:** start here. Ask for honest feedback, then ask for introductions.
- **Neighborhood Facebook group:** check the group rules first. Many allow business posts on certain days.
- **Schools, churches and clubs:** teacher gifts, bake sales, fundraisers and community events.
- **Local markets and craft fairs:** a small table is enough. Offer samples if the rules allow.
- **Pre-orders by message:** take orders for the weekend so you make only what is sold.

Sample neighborhood group post

Copy and adapt

Hi neighbors! I'm starting a small home-based popcorn project and I'm making three flavors this weekend: Classic Caramel, Rainbow Sprinkle and White Cheddar. Snack bags are $4, gift bags are $10. Pre-order by replying here or sending me a message, and I'll set a pickup time. Happy to answer questions about ingredients and allergens!

Sample message to a friend

Copy and adapt

Hi! I'm trying out a little popcorn project. Would you be willing to try a free sample and tell me what you honestly think? If you like it, I'm taking pre-orders for this weekend. And if you know someone who loves treats, I'd love an introduction.

Sample message to a school or club organizer

Copy and adapt

Hello! I make small-batch gourmet popcorn at home and would love to help with your next event, either as treat bags for a class or as part of a fundraiser. I can share flavors, sizes and ingredient lists. Would it be possible to talk about what would work for you?

Sample follow-up after a sale

Copy and adapt

Thank you so much for your order! I hope you enjoy it. If you liked it, I'd really appreciate it if you told one friend. And if there's a flavor you'd like to see next, let me know.

Take clear photos in daylight, show the bag next to a bowl of popcorn, and mention the flavor and size. Be upfront about ingredients and allergens. Trust is what turns a first sale into a regular customer.

8. Your first-weekend plan

BEFORE THE WEEKEND

- [ ] Read your state's cottage food rules and note what applies to you
- [ ] Confirm what registration, if any, is required
- [ ] Choose 2 to 3 flavors and 3 bag sizes
- [ ] Write down your cost per bag and your prices
- [ ] Buy ingredients, bags, ties and label materials
- [ ] Design and print a simple label, with your state's required items
- [ ] Take your photo and write your post

FRIDAY

- [ ] Post in your neighborhood group (if allowed) and message friends
- [ ] Make the first batch and test one bag for freshness
- [ ] Package a few sample bags

SATURDAY

- [ ] Make the remaining batches in the morning, let them cool and dry completely
- [ ] Bag and label everything
- [ ] Deliver or hand over pre-orders
- [ ] Write down feedback and sales

SUNDAY

- [ ] Follow up with each buyer
- [ ] Calculate cost, income and your hourly result
- [ ] Pick one flavor to keep, one to change, and one to try next
- [ ] Plan your next event or market

Next step

Pick one flavor from the recipe collection, make a test batch today, and write down your cost per bag. Then look up your state's cottage food rules, choose your three sizes and send your first message to a friend. Small, honest steps are how every home food business starts.